Notes on using the ICA codebook

What this codebook captures

This codebook records methodological and reporting features of published item-content analyses (ICAs). Its purpose is to describe how ICAs were conducted and reported across studies.

Descriptive rather than evaluative

The coding is descriptive. Variables are used to capture what a study reports and how the analysis was conducted, not to rate methodological quality against a fixed standard.

Missing and ambiguous information is meaningful

Unclear reporting is itself informative. If a variable could in principle be coded but the paper is too vague or incomplete, it should be coded as indeterminable.

Structural inapplicability is different from missing information

NA is reserved for cases in which a variable is not applicable by design. indeterminable is used when the variable would be applicable, but the reporting is too unclear to code.

One study, one row

The extraction sheet generally follows a one-study-one-row format. If a paper reports multiple ICA analyses based on different instrument sets but uses the same general workflow, procedural variables are coded once at the paper level and aggregated values are noted accordingly.

Multi-value cells

Some variables can contain more than one value per study (e.g., multiple databases or frameworks). These entries are recorded within one cell and separated by semicolons.

Notes are part of the coding

If a judgement call, ambiguity, or special case cannot be captured cleanly in the main variables, it should be recorded in the notes column.

General strategy

1. Read the full paper and relevant supplements.
2. Code the procedural and reporting variables study by study.
3. Use indeterminable when information is too vague or incomplete to classify confidently.
4. Use NA only when a variable is structurally not applicable.
5. Record special cases, uncertainties, and aggregation decisions in the notes.
6. Revisit earlier coding decisions if a paper makes a category definition clearer later in the text